

When a Dentist and Chiropractor Meet the Same Sleep Apnea Patient

Who Leads, Who Supports, and Why Sequence Matters

Introduction — The New Kid in the Sandbox

- Sleep apnea patients are entering dental and chiropractic offices more than ever
- Dentists and chiropractors often “see” the same patient at the same time
- Without a shared framework, care becomes fragmented

This document explains **how coordination works best**, and **why sequence matters**.

Section 1 — Why Dentists Often Open the Door First

- Dentists already screen airway
- CBCT imaging provides visual authority
- The first apnea conversation feels natural in a dental setting

This is not about ownership.
It's about **patient acceptance**.

Section 2 — Why CBCT Alone Is Not Enough

CBCT may show:

- airway narrowing
- jaw position
- craniofacial anatomy

But it does **not** show:

- spinal curve load
- pelvic imbalance

- respiratory mechanics
- postural compensation
- foot–spine relationships

A narrow airway is a **local finding**.

Sleep apnea is a **global condition**.

Section 3 — The Chiropractor as Biomechanical Integrator

A post-graduate trained chiropractor evaluates:

- posture (CBP)
- pelvis and SIJ (SOT / AK)
- cranial mechanics (BNS / CFR)
- spinal loading
- foot–pelvis–spine integration

This evaluation answers one question:

Will an oral appliance help—or create new problems—without correcting global mechanics?

Section 4 — The Proper Role of the Oral Appliance

Oral appliances:

- can support airway patency
- can reduce collapse
- must be chosen carefully

Selection must be a **co-decision**:

- DDS evaluates dental tolerance
- DC evaluates biomechanical consequences

Both providers should be trained on the device.

Section 5 — The Ideal Sequence (Clean, Ethical, Effective)

1. DDS identifies airway concern
2. DDS refers to DC for whole-system evaluation
3. DC evaluates biomechanics
4. DDS and DC select appliance together
5. Appliance delivered
6. DC reassesses global mechanics
7. Adjustments and supports added as needed

No turf war.

No duplication.

No guessing.

Section 6 — Why This Protects Everyone

- Dentists reduce chair time and liability
 - Chiropractors practice within scope
 - Manufacturers stay in their lane
 - Patients get better outcomes
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Conclusion — The Playground Has Rules

When everyone knows the rules of the playground,
the new kid doesn't get hurt — and everyone wins.

Final Thought (You Should Keep This)

Dentists open the door.

Chiropractors assess the whole house.

Oral appliances support the structure — they don't replace it.
